

CHAPTER ONE

1.0 Introduction to SIWES

Student Industrial Work Experience Scheme (SIWES) is a special program designed to expose and prepare students of higher institutions of learning on practical aspect of their profession. Before the establishment of SIWES, there was a growing concern among industrialist that graduates of institutions of higher learning lack adequate practical experience suitable for employment. Thus, employers are of the opinion that theory-oriented system of education going on in higher institutions was not responsive to their needs. It is against this background that the rationale for initiating and designing the scheme was hinged.

1.1 History of SIWES

The Student Industrial Work Experience Scheme (SIWES), launched by the ITF in 1973, is your opportunity to turn academic theory into practical expertise. This program is specifically designed to prepare students for the demands of the modern workplace by providing hands-on experience with industry tools, machines, and equipment that colleges might not have. By completing SIWES, you gain the competence and confidence that employers look for, making you highly employable.

SIWES will help you:

- Practice Your Knowledge: See how your lessons apply in a professional environment.
- Master the Ropes: Learn the actual work methods and techniques used in your field.
- Develop Core Skills: Gain valuable technical, management, and people skills.
- Step into a Career: Prepare for a confident move from campus life to the job market.
- Be Mentored: Grow yourself by working closely with experienced professionals.

1.2 Relevance of SIWES to My Course Of Study

As a student of horticulture, my Students' Industrial Work Experience Scheme (SIWES) training provided invaluable hands-on exposure to the foundational practices of the field. My experience allowed me to gain practical skills in several key areas, including:

- **Plant Propagation:** Mastering techniques for cuttings, grafting, and seed starting.
- **Soil Science and Fertility Management:** Performing soil analysis, understanding nutrient requirements, and applying appropriate fertilizers and amendments.
- **Pest and Disease Management (IPM):** Identifying common plant pests and pathogens and implementing integrated management strategies.
- **Nursery Management:** Learning the daily operations of a nursery, from potting and spacing to irrigation schedules.
- **Crop Establishment and Field Operations:** Gaining experience in site preparation, planting, pruning, and harvesting.

These specialized skills are fundamental to successful crop production, landscape design, and sustainable agri-business. By working directly with plant materials, specialized equipment, and diagnostic tools, I was able to bridge the gap between theoretical classroom knowledge and real-world horticultural practice. This experience was critical in strengthening my technical expertise while also cultivating essential professional attributes such as patience, precision, teamwork, and problem-solving skills—all of which are vital for a career in modern horticulture.

1.3 Aim and Objectives of SIWES

The primary aim of SIWES is to bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge acquired in educational institutions and the practical application of skills required in the workplace. It specifically focuses on equipping students with practical industrial experience and building a pool of locally trained, skilled manpower for the Nigerian economy.

Objectives

The SIWES program is designed to achieve the following specific objectives:

1. **Acquire Practical Skills :** To enable students to gain real-world industrial skills, experience, and practical knowledge relevant to their approved course of study.

2. Apply Theoretical Knowledge : To provide an opportunity for students to apply and test the theoretical concepts learned in the classroom within a real-life work setting.
3. Exposure to Industrial Equipment : To expose students to the practical methods and techniques of operating equipment and machinery that might not be available at their respective institutions.
4. Workplace Readiness : To prepare students for the professional work environments, challenges, and expectations they are likely to encounter upon graduation.
5. Technical Report Writing : To help students understand the characteristics of a meaningful technical report and provide them with the guidance and skills necessary to improve the quality of reports they produce.
6. Manpower Development : To promote the acquisition of essential skills in industry and commerce, thereby generating a sufficient pool of indigenous trained manpower to meet the needs of the Nigerian economy and support small-scale industrialization.

1.4 BODIES INVOLVED IN THE MANAGEMENT OF SIWES

The Students Industrial Work Experience Scheme (SIWES) was established on October 8th by the Industrial Training Fund (ITF) in 1973 under the Ministry of Education. It operates according to Decree 4047 of Nigerian law. Funded by the Federal Government of Nigeria, the scheme is jointly coordinated by the ITF and the National Universities Commission (NUC).

SIWES is a nationwide skills training program for students in all Nigerian tertiary institutions, primarily designed to give students in Nigerian tertiary institutions an opportunity to gain industrial skills and hands-on experience directly related to their academic fields.